

Cut



Pale carving stands out

Composite cameo | The layering of agate lends itself to cameo work. This example has a carved figure applied to a background of mossy agate.

Moss-like mineral inclusions



Chlorite

Moss agate cabochon | The cabochon cut shows off the mineral inclusions, often chlorite, as here, which give the appearance of moss growing within the agate stone.

Settings



Mineral inclusions resemble moss

Agate bowl | The polished surface of this shallow bowl carved from moss agate shows the intricate appearance of the stone. The irregular form of the piece complements the natural, random pattern of the gem.

Colour



Dyed area

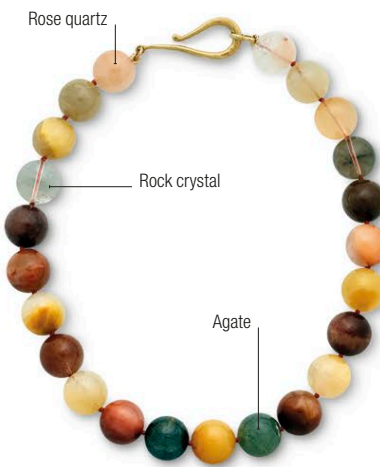
Crystallized agate

Dyed agate | Agate is relatively porous, and so it can easily be dyed. Blue, as here, is typical; red or purple are also common. It can be difficult to tell dyed agate from natural.



Iron oxide inclusions

Fire agate cabochon | The cabochon cut of this fire agate stone brings out its natural iridescence. Its bubbling, oily appearance is caused by iron oxide inclusions.



Rose quartz

Rock crystal

Agate

Multicoloured necklace | This necklace combines spherical beads of a number of quartz minerals, including agate, rose quartz, and rock crystal.



Naturally coloured banding

Silver-mounted brooch | Typical of Celtic-style pieces produced from the 19th century, the agate used for this brooch was recovered from the beaches of northern Scotland.

In the Middle Ages, wearing agate was thought to cure insomnia and ensure sweet dreams



Manganese staining

Moss agate | In this cabochon, the "moss" is in fact staining from one of the iron or manganese oxides that penetrated the agate after it was formed.

Types of agate

Lace and fire

Fire agate is an unusual variety that has iridescent rainbow colours, with brown to honey-coloured base material. Cutting is a meticulous process, removing only enough stone to reveal the "fire". Fortification agate is a general term for banded agate with angularly arranged bands. Brazilian agate is a fortification agate with banding in angled concentric circles, and Mexican lace agate – called "crazy-lace" – is a multicoloured fortification agate with convoluted layering.



Lace agate rough This uncut piece of Mexican lace agate shows the intricate swirls and folds typical of its patterning.